

# Upgraded Helicopters

The hiatus between the end of the Cold War and the start of the War on Terror made this a fallow decade for military helicopter sales, especially for Soviet and Eastern Bloc manufacturers. Many 1990s helicopters were upgrades of existing machines for specialized civilian work, such as the oil industry.



## ◀ AS 555 Fennec 1992

**Origin** France

**Engine** 2 x 456 shp Turbomeca TM319 Arrius 1M turboshaft

**Top speed** 178 mph (287 km/h)

This aircraft was a twin-engined military version of the venerable and globally popular Ecuriel (Squirrel) line. The 1990s upgrades included navigation, radar, autopilot, and weapons systems.



## △ Robinson R44 1991

**Origin** USA

**Engine** Lycoming IO-540-AE1A5 piston

**Top speed** 149 mph (240 km/h)

With purchase, maintenance, and running costs that were astoundingly low by helicopter standards, the four-place R44 became and remains the world's bestselling helicopter.

## ▷ MD900 Explorer 1992

**Origin** USA

**Engine** 2 x 550 shp Pratt & Whitney PW206E turboshaft

**Top speed** 161 mph (259 km/h)

The Explorer's twin-engined transport uses a patented "notar" system that utilized main rotor downwash to create antitorque force on the tail boom, reducing noise and increasing safety.



## △ DragonFly 333 1993

**Origin** Italy

**Engine** 110 hp Hirth F30A26AK two-stroke piston

**Top speed** 83 mph (134 km/h)

This Italian ultralight model, weighing only 622 lb (282 kg) empty, was designed by two Italian brothers—an archaeologist and a film-maker—for their personal use, then put into limited production.



## ◀ Bell 230 1991

**Origin** USA

**Engine** 2 x 700 shp Allison 250-C30G2 turboshaft

**Top speed** 172 mph (277 km/h)

This was a more powerful variant of the Bell 222, available with skids or wheels. It was superseded by the Bell 430 after four years, with only 38 Bell 230s built.



## △ Bell 407 1994

**Origin** USA

**Engine** 813 shp Allison 250-C47B turboshaft

**Top speed** 161 mph (259 km/h)

Designed to supersede the ubiquitous but long-in-the-tooth Bell 206 JetRanger, the 407 had a four-bladed main rotor, better performance, and more internal space.